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MAIL ATTACHMENTS Less is more

E-mail attachments are not only an essential part of daily communication but also a source of fun and amusement. Remember the document with jokes that had you in stitches for hours? Or the spreadsheet-based quiz that passed a cool 20 minutes of an otherwise mundane day? And surely the important presentation to your boss could not have gone as smoothly if you were not able to mail yourself that 200 KB Power-Point slide! The fun ends when the e-mail attachments grow bigger though. Attachments that exceed 1 MB in size are not unheard of. And this is where things take a frustrating turn. If you know that the large attachment in question is important, then you grit your teeth and bear the agony of downloading it. But what if the source of the file is unknown? Is it something essential? Could it be a virus? Perhaps another one of those stupid ads? A prank? You will never know until you download and open the attachment. And heaven help you if you are stuck on a dial-up line!

Most e-mail clients offer options to filter your mail. This feature lets you sort mail on the basis of the size of the incoming mail. You can also reject mail that exceeds a particular size limit. The latter option is the best, albeit a risky means to escape large attachments. If you go for this option, remember to turn off the filter when you are expecting a large and important e-mail. A safer alternative is to set up a Web-based account. The nature of such services means that you need not download an attachment to your computer until you are absolutely certain of its content. Some Web-based services also offer a nifty preview mode that lets you take a peek inside an attachment before you decide to junk it.

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PORN Sex sells

Even if you do not buy the above truism, you can do little to escape the inevitable: pornographic material is as ubiquitous on the Internet as oxygen is in the offline world. And like air, adult content essentially keeps a lot of people alive by raking in the much-needed money. There is no avoiding porn; it will not go away anytime soon, or anytime at all. If it offends your sensibilities, all you can do is take precautionary steps. Almost any Web-browser lets you turn off images and animations. Use this feature if you are browsing a site that hosts adult images and banner ads. A lot of advertisements touting sex take the form of popup and pop-under ads. These can be eradicated as explained in Net Nasty 4. Newsletters and mailing lists can also be a source of pornographic material. If you do not know whether a particular service is guilty of such practices, create a public e-mail account and use that to ascertain the facts. Remember that these steps will only reduce an encounter with pornographic content and not eliminate it all together.

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SPYWARE You are being watched

Chances are that one of the programs that you gleefully installed the other day is spyware. A spyware is a program that offers you services such as a funky toolbar for your favourite browser, then promptly and secretly steals your personal details! It has been known to collect information ranging from your browsing habits such as the Web sites you frequently visit and the ads you often click on, to your credit card details. It then sells this vital knowledge to interested parties for a healthy exchange of money. It is a sad state of affairs and things will only get worse. But there is a respite in the guise of software programs that scan your computer system to identify spyware and help you banish them. One such program, perhaps the best of the lot, is called Ad-Aware (www.lavasoftusa.com).

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According to a conservative estimate, there are a total of 927 spyware programs out there, a majority of them being Peer-to-Peer services such as KaZaA

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POORLY DESIGNED WEB SITES Aaarrrgh! It's hurting my eyes!

The World Wide Web came of age in the year 1996. Web sites then were crude rudimentary creations with bad colour choices, pathetic navigational solutions and poor programming. People were still learning the ropes and things were expected to get better.

Six years down the line, poorly designed Web sites still form a rather large percentage of the online world. Let it be known that blue text on a black background isn't retina friendly. And do all those images need to be 500 KB? Mr Programmer, will you please read the W3C (the World Wide Web Consortium) recommendations so that your elite Web site displays like it should on my Mozilla browser? Get with it people!

**SpamNet, AntiVir, Pop-Up
Stopper, Ad-Aware**
Find it in Software > Internet
on the Mindware CD

